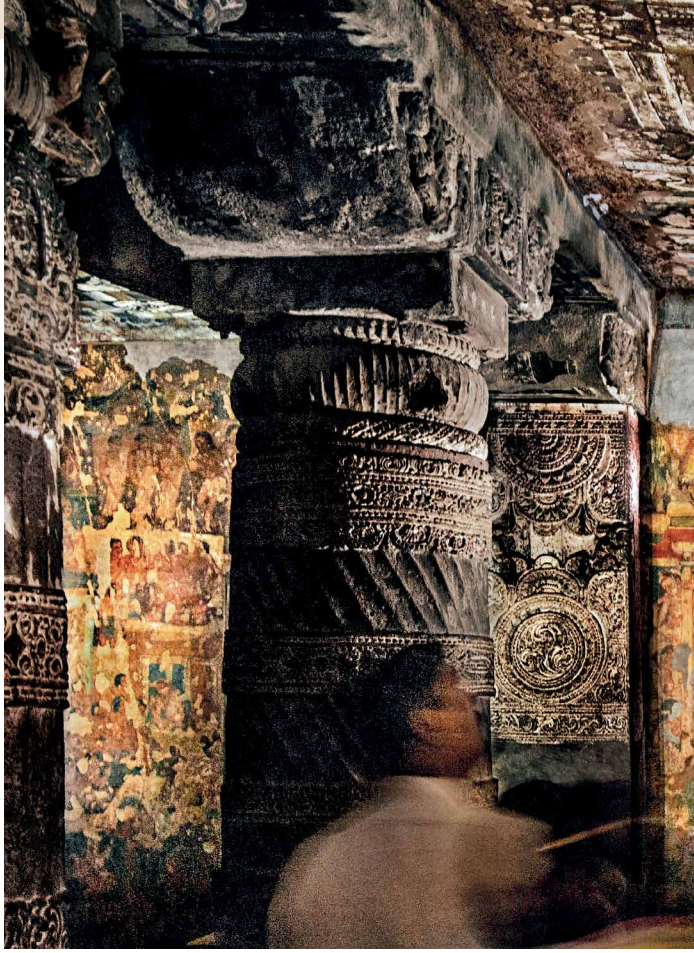


of India's rock-cut caves by Burgess and Fergusson, published 1880, which still stands like the Old Testament on the subject, systematically brought alive a forgotten aesthetic universe. Concern for its precarity shaped the story from the beginning. Major Robert Gill spent three decades "at Adjunta", painstakingly copying 30 murals—all but four of his life-size copies were destroyed in two London fires. John Griffiths followed in 1872—the 1885 Victoria & Albert Museum fire consumed the bulk of his copies too. Both, in their preservative urgency, applied varnish on the murals. A disastrous choice: by 1884, it was already "flaking off"—with the paint. Japanese artist Kampo Arai, whose copies from 1917, too, eerily invited the fire curse, said the varnish had made the surface "greasy, (of) unpleasant appearance" and "changed the colour of the paintings". Nature's gremlins were still there too. The husband of suffragette Lady Christiana Herringham, who left behind the pompadours and fine hats of Edwardian England to copy the murals in 1909-11, wrote shudderingly of "the gibbering bats sidling along the rock cornices...in the deep recesses". They all did hours lying face up to the ceiling on scaffolding, copying fine detail from fifth century brushwork, as leopards and bears prowled nearby.

The Nizam of Hyderabad, in whose dominion Ajanta fell, came next. His legendary archaeologist Ghulam Yazdani produced the first modern photographic reproductions, in colour and monochrome, by 1930. Around him, modern Indian art was being deeply touched by Ajanta—feeding the Bengal School's famous 'Indian turn', away from European modernism. Asit Haldar, who had helped Lady Herringham, carried Ajanta almost intact into his art. The encounter was transformative also for that stormy petrel, Amrita Sher-Gil—Ajanta's phantasmic shadows animate her South Indian Trilogy. The Nizam also invited one of the world's best restoration experts, Lorenzo Cecconi, who had once been called upon to inspect the Mona Lisa. Alas, this was a particularly sharp double-edged sword. Yazdani thought Cecconi and his assistant Count Orsini had extended Ajanta's life by "at least a couple of centuries". Manager Singh, surveying the handiwork of his predecessor, half-concurs: "If he had not consolidated all those bits of crumbling plaster, the murals would have long gone." A zinc drain "inserted in the inner aisle of Cave 1" probably saved the iconic Padmapani that graces our cover. But Cecconi, trying to undo Victorian damage, resorted to solutions that today read like a catalogue of the innocent follies of early science—diluted mixtures of alcohol, turpentine, caustic soda, hydrochloric acid, ammonia and, most disastrously, liberal coatings of unbleached shellac. Today, we see that ancient art filtered by its dull and evil sunset patina.

This site of devastation is what Manager Singh inherited. New tools of the craft were at hand: X-Ray Fluorescence, FTIR Spectroscopy, Micro-Raman et al. His team went to work in 1998, proceeding cave by cave, six people covering one square inch a day, teasing out the offending shellac, varnish and soot. Cyclododecane bound pigment as "wet Japanese tissue paper" took off bat guano; ethyl silicate secured sculptures; rock got Wacker. Next-generation chemicals, but chemicals nevertheless. In a world moving fast to newer paradigms—like microbiological interventions—that approach is not without sceptics. Colonial varnish, too, was slathered on with good intentions.

WAXING AND WANING OF EFFORTS

Most visitors miss one of Ajanta's architectural marvels: it's a white elephant, just off the parking lot, called the 'Ajanta Visitor Centre'. Funded with a soft loan by the Japanese International Cooperation Agency (JICA), it was meant to be a showpiece of the Ajanta-Ellora Development Plan (AEDP) Phase II, and a lynchpin of modern site management—weaning away a good percentage of footfalls to that four-and-a-half-acre museum and orientation centre under the Maharashtra Tourism Development Corporation (MTDC), thus depopulating the caves. That's how they do it around the world. "In China's Mogao Caves, two visitor centres over miles soak up 95 per cent of the visitors; most return satisfied and exhausted," says conservator Gurmeet Rai, whose panel prepared the site management plan for Ellora in 2010. Spain's Altamira used to let in only five visitors per week. Lascaux, in France, was more extreme: it's strictly no go. Both sites treat visitors to replica cave art.

India's version was conceived of in the mid-'90s; work